Breaking Free from Perfectionism: When High Standards Become a Trap

An 8-lesson CBT course on the transdiagnostic pattern behind anxiety, depression, OCD, and burnout

Not All Perfectionism Is Harmful

Have you ever spent hours reworking something already good enough — or avoided starting because you were afraid it wouldn't be perfect?

Healthy High Standards

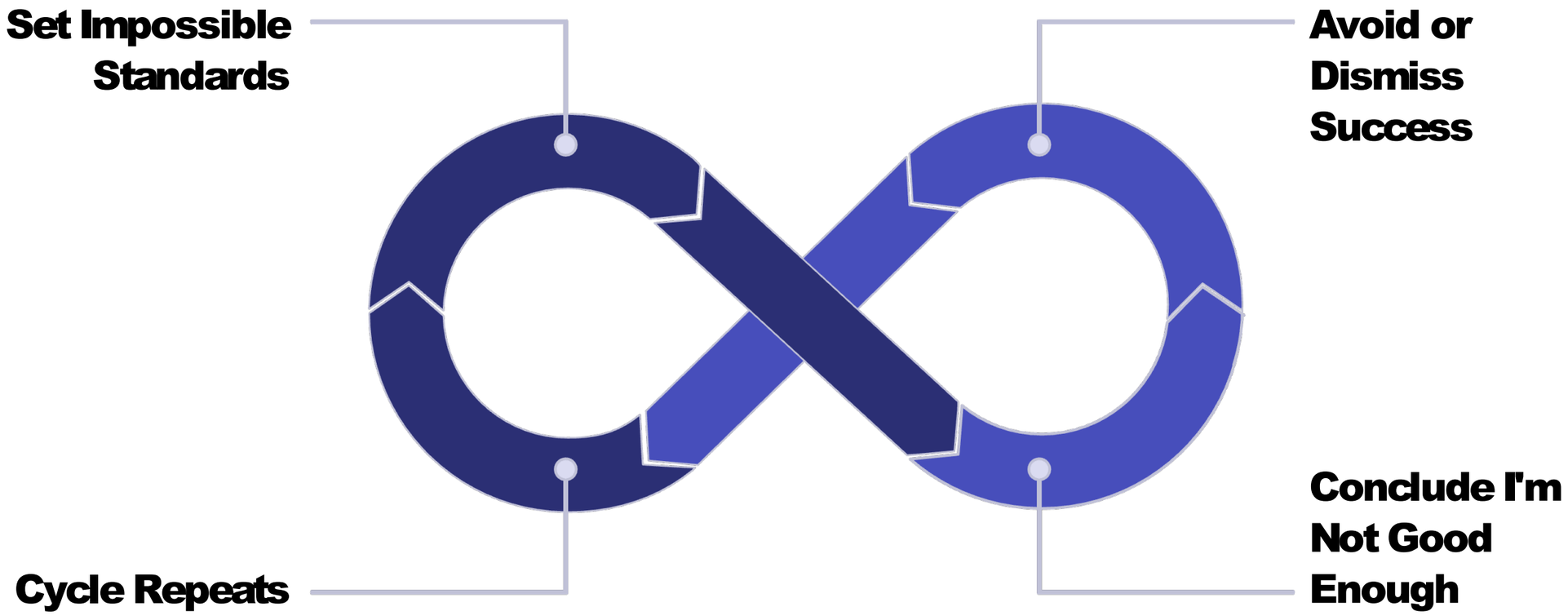
Push you to grow, improve, and achieve meaningful goals. Standards that motivate and energize — leaving room for satisfaction when you succeed.

Maladaptive Perfectionism

Keeps you stuck in a relentless cycle of fear, procrastination, and self-criticism. No achievement ever feels like enough.

The Perfectionism Trap

Perfectionism is self-reinforcing — success is never satisfying, and failure confirms your worst fear. Here's how the cycle works:



The trap is airtight: whether you fail *or* succeed, the conclusion is always the same — **"I'm not good enough."** Breaking the cycle requires changing the rules of the game entirely.

What You'll Learn

Eight carefully sequenced lessons guide you from understanding your patterns to building lasting flexibility:

1. **Adaptive vs. Maladaptive Standards**
   Distinguish healthy high standards from perfectionistic concerns that hold you back.

2. **Your Personal Patterns**
   Identify your own rigid rules, self-criticism habits, and procrastination triggers.

3. **Cognitive Restructuring**
   Challenge perfectionistic thinking with evidence-based CBT techniques.

4. **Behavioral Experiments**
   Deliberately test "good enough" in real situations and observe what actually happens.

5. **Exposure to Imperfection**
   Reduce checking behaviors and build tolerance for uncertainty and mistakes.

6. **Deeper Schemas**
   Explore core beliefs like "I am only worthwhile if I achieve" and where they come from.

7. **Self-Compassionate Alternatives**
   Develop a kinder inner voice to replace the relentless inner perfectionist.

8. **Long-Term Flexibility**
   Build resilience, prevent relapse, and sustain your progress over time.

A Transdiagnostic Pattern

Perfectionism isn't a standalone problem — it's a **core pattern that simultaneously fuels multiple conditions**. Treating perfectionism often improves all of them at once.

Anxiety

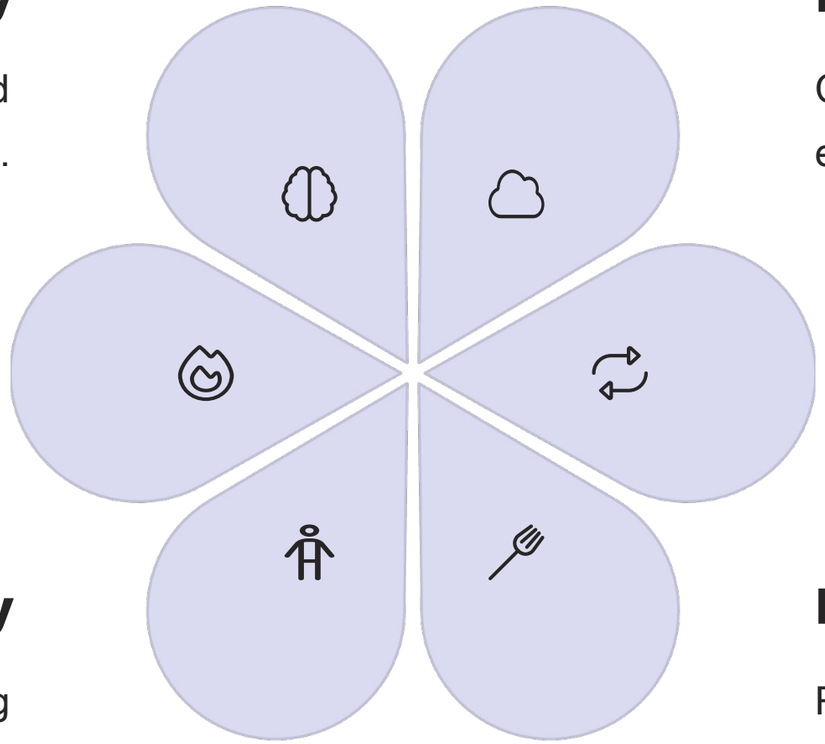
Fear of failure drives constant worry and avoidance.

Burnout

Relentless overwork driven by impossibly high self-demands.

Social Anxiety

Fear of judgment and performing imperfectly in front of others.



Depression

Chronic self-criticism and unmet standards erode mood.

OCD

Compulsive checking and "just right" rituals rooted in perfectionism.

Eating Disorders

Rigid rules around food, body, and control.

Course Structure

A complete, self-paced program built on the best available evidence in CBT and schema therapy.

8

Lessons

Carefully sequenced from awareness to lasting change.

8–10

Hours Total

Flexible, self-paced learning that fits your schedule.

CBT-Based

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy techniques proven to reduce perfectionistic thinking and behavior.

Schema-Informed

Goes deeper than surface habits to address the core beliefs driving perfectionism.

Evidence-Based

Grounded in clinical research on perfectionism as a transdiagnostic process.

Self-Paced

Work through lessons at your own pace, revisiting material whenever you need it.